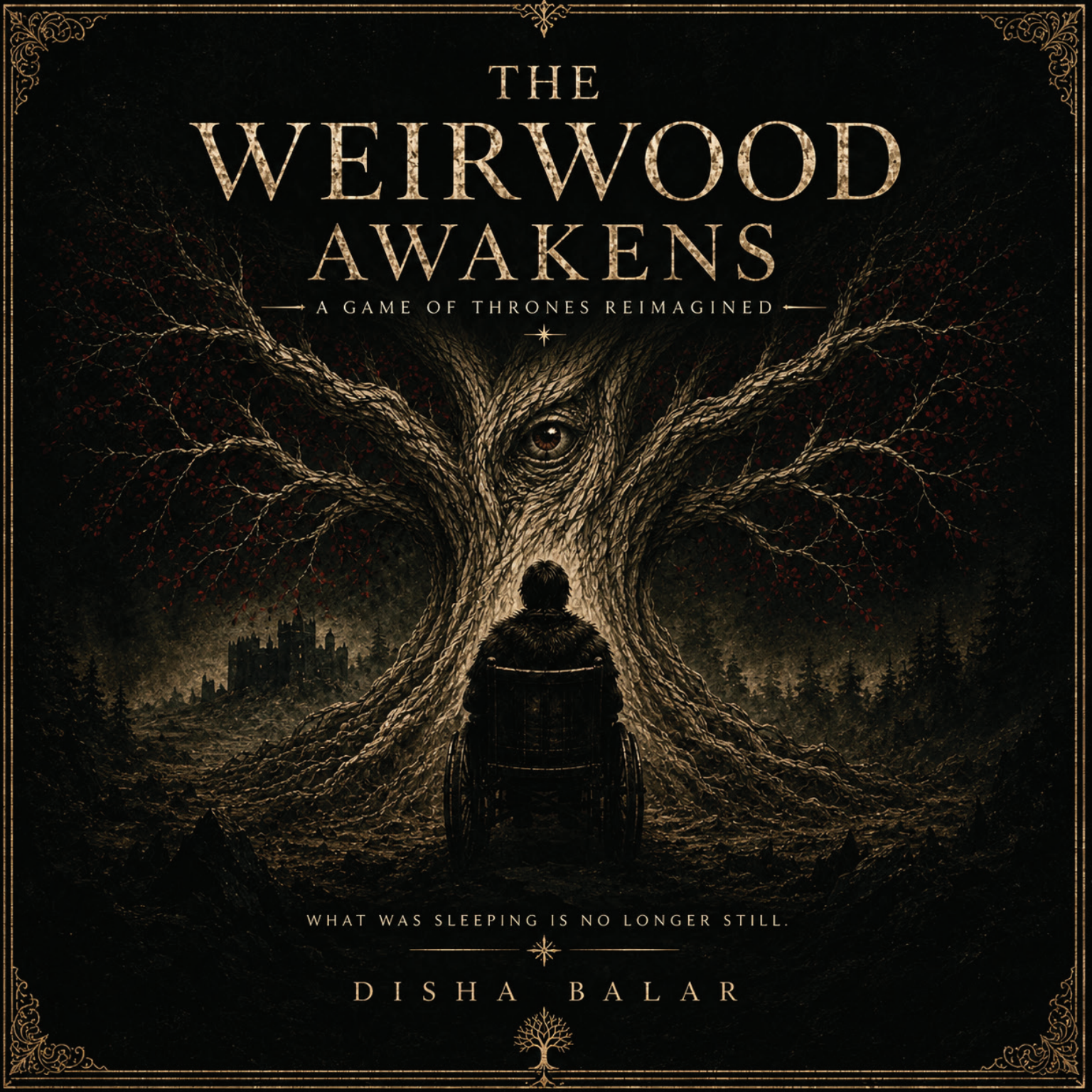
THE
NARROW
SEA
WINTERFELL
THE NORTH

THE WEIRWOOD AWAKENS

A GAME OF THRONES REIMAGINED



WHAT WAS SLEEPING IS NO LONGER STILL.

DISHA BALAR

"They killed the guardian. They called it a victory."
THE
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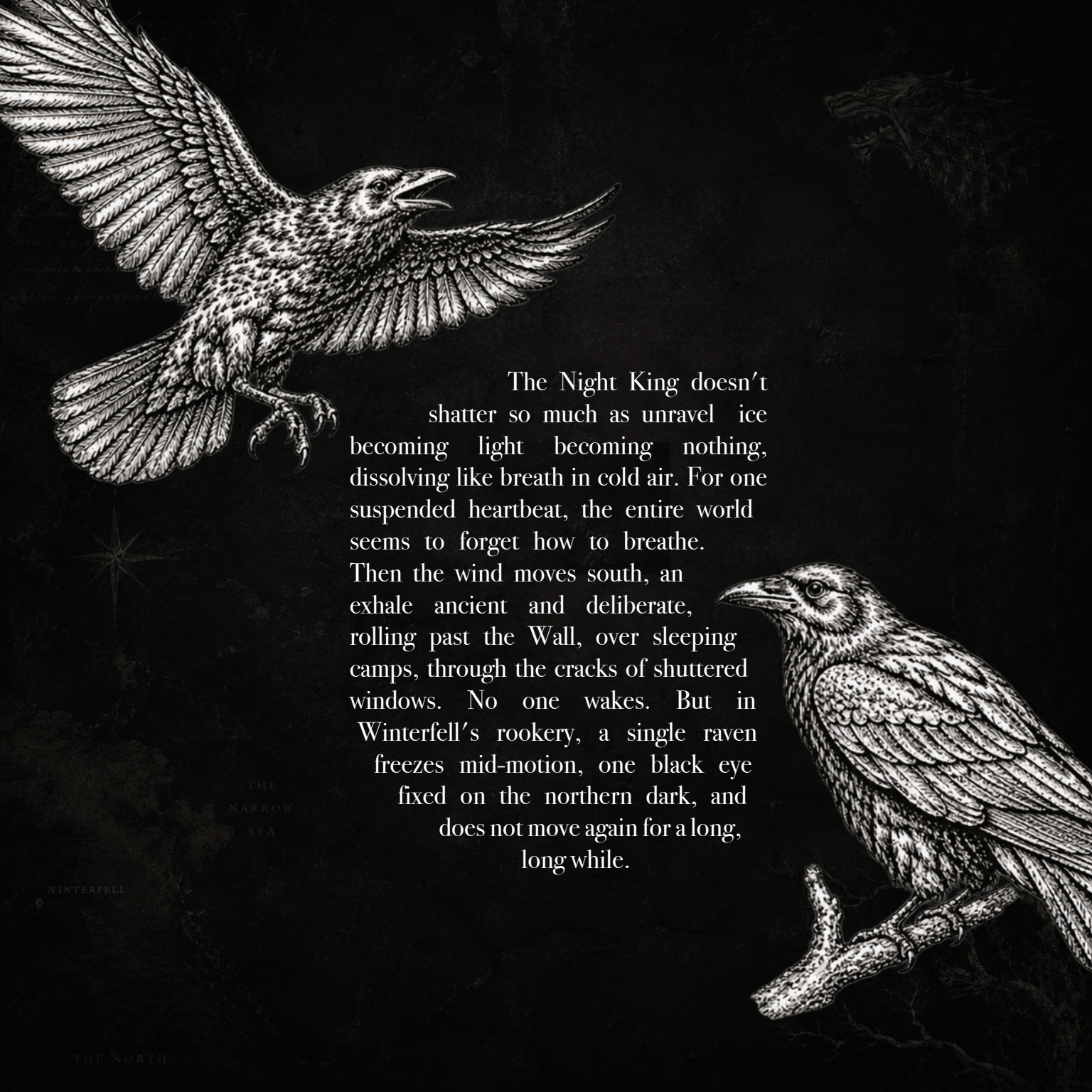
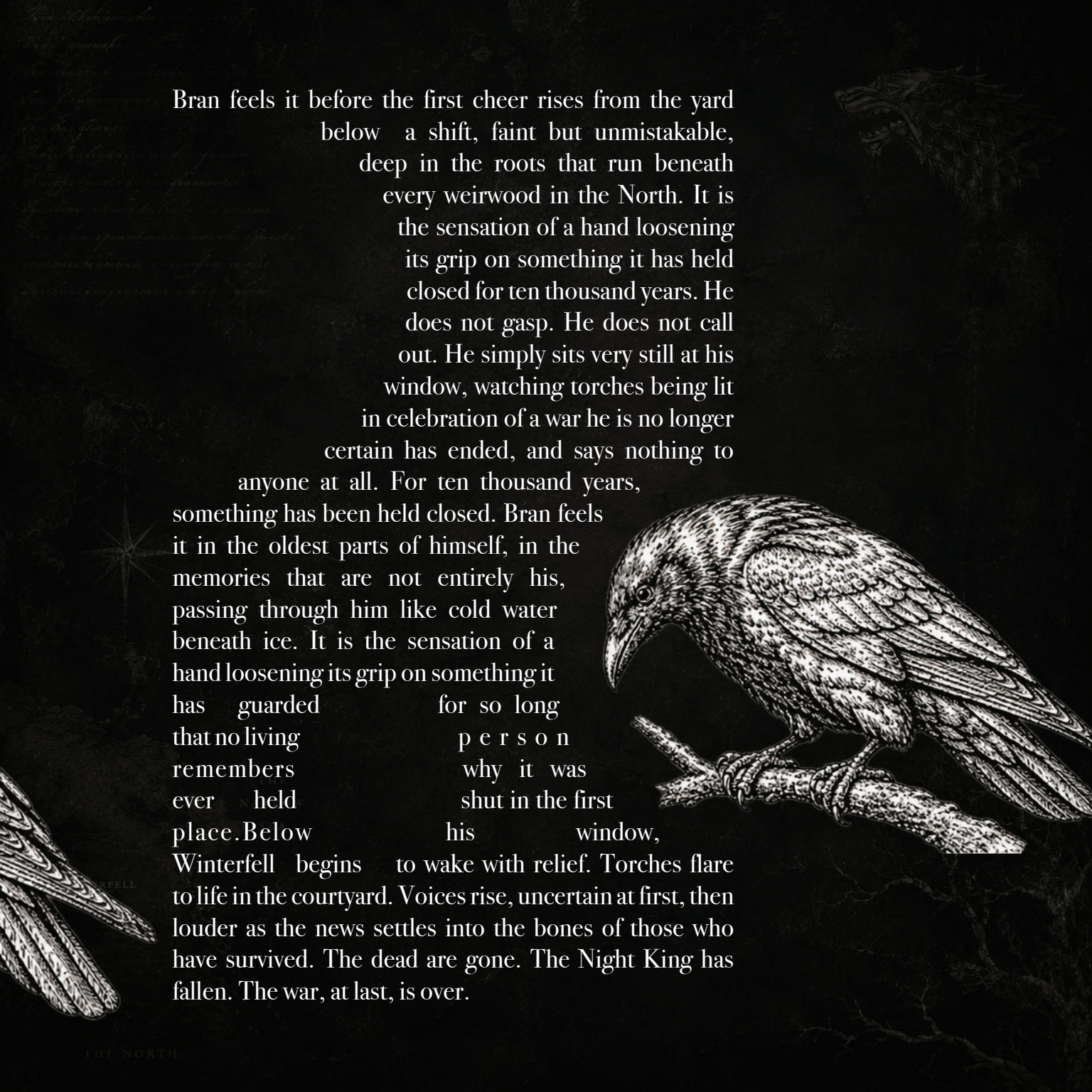
For eight years, Westeros has known one war above all others the war against the dead, ended at last beneath the walls of Winterfell. The realm calls it a victory. Bran Stark calls it something else, though he hasn′t yet found the word. What follows are the last quiet days before he does.



The Night King doesn't shatter so much as unravel ice becoming light becoming nothing, dissolving like breath in cold air. For one suspended heartbeat, the entire world seems to forget how to breathe.

Then the wind moves south, an exhale ancient and deliberate, rolling past the Wall, over sleeping camps, through the cracks of shuttered windows. No one wakes. But in Winterfell's rookery, a single raven freezes mid-motion, one black eye fixed on the northern dark, and does not move again for a long, long while.

Bran feels it before the first cheer rises from the yard below a shift, faint but unmistakable, deep in the roots that run beneath every weirwood in the North. It is the sensation of a hand loosening its grip on something it has held closed for ten thousand years. He does not gasp. He does not call out. He simply sits very still at his window, watching torches being lit in celebration of a war he is no longer certain has ended, and says nothing to anyone at all. For ten thousand years, something has been held closed. Bran feels it in the oldest parts of himself, in the memories that are not entirely his, passing through him like cold water beneath ice. It is the sensation of a hand loosening its grip on something it has guarded for so long that no living person remembers why it was ever held shut in the first place. Below his window, Winterfell begins to wake with relief. Torches flare to life in the courtyard. Voices rise, uncertain at first, then louder as the news settles into the bones of those who have survived. The dead are gone. The Night King has fallen. The war, at last, is over.



Winter

erupts into the kind of joy it has not tasted in years wine poured freely, music drifting warm through candlelit halls. Jon laughs, a real laugh, unguarded, the sound of a man finally allowed to set his burden down. Sansa raises her cup mid-toast, then falters, noticing Bran's sits untouched.

"You're not celebrating," she says quietly, searching his face. Bran doesn't look away from the black glass window. "Not yet."

Long after the fires die down and the halls fall quiet with sleep, Bran wheels himself alone into the godswood, where the air feels thicker, older, watchful. He reaches out and presses his palm flat against the ancient bark.

fell

It's warm not sun-warmed, not fire-warmed, but warm the way skin is warm, the way something alive is warm. He pulls his hand back slowly, breath fogging in the dark, and for the first time in years, Bran Stark is afraid.

Tyrion about him isn′t grief, and it isn′t the flat relief of a war finally won. A careful, practiced The expression of someone holding a thought so enormous that speaking it aloud might give it shape..And somewhere beyond the walls of Winterfell, beneath ice, stone, and ten thousand years of silence, something answers with a pulse no one .

What unsettles him about Bran isn′t grief, nor the relief of a war finally won. It is the careful, practiced blankness of a man holding something enormous inside himself. Around him, Winterfell celebrates. Wine is poured. Laughter fills the halls. Yet Bran′s cup remains untouched. Tyrion watches him from across the room and slowly begins to understand that Bran knows something. Not something that willhappen.Something that has already begun.The war is over. At least, that is what everyone is telling themselves. The halls are filled with wine and exhausted laughter.As if it was all or he

Thatsame night, Jon dr
ice not a reflection dancing on a froze
and patient smoldering deep in the
should exist at all. He stands alone
surrounded by darkness. Beneath his
once, then again.on kneels and press
frozen surface. The cold burns, bu
something else: warmth. A slow, r
heartbeat trying to remember how
impossible moment, something
him.Jonwakesgasping,damp with
hand still stretched into the
reachesinstinctively for a swor
there and remains awake long aft
fades, listening to the
Winterfell.Elsewhere, Tyrion
Bran.He has spent a lifetime
read rooms, courts, and the dangerou
watches him from the room and

reams of fire burning beneath
n surface, but something vast
dark water where no fire
on an endless field of ice,
s feet, a faint glow pulses
ses his palm against the
ut beneath it he feels
hythmic pulse, likea
w to beatFor one
moves far below
cold sweat, his
darkness.a He
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"Is
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truly over?"

Sansa finds Bran again beneath the ancient weirwood and this time asks nothing, only sits beside him in the cold, patient, letting the silence stretch until he′s ready to fill it himself. When he finally speaks, his voice is quiet, almost reluctant, as if saying it aloud makes it more true. ″He wasn′t the enemy, Sansa. He was the lock.″ She turns the words over, waiting for them to make sense. They don′t. Not yet.

At first light, sap weeps from the weirwood′s carved eyes thick and slow, far darker than it should be, nearly black, cooling into the snow before it can even properly run. The maester summoned to examine it turns the sample over in his fingers for a long, uneasy time and offers no explanation he′s willing to commit to paper. He excuses himself from dinner untouched, and cannot shake the feeling that something ancient has quietly, patiently, begun to bleed.

THE DROP
What Begins to Bleed

A single drop of dark sap marks the first visible sign that something beneath Winterfell has changed. The tree is no longer simply watching. Something ancient has begun to move through it.

THE EYE
What Watches Back

The carved eye represents the weirwood itself: memory, knowledge, and the feeling that Bran is no longer the only one looking through the trees. For the first time, something may be looking back.

THE RAVEN
What Knows

The raven connects this moment to the first unnatural silence after the Night King's fall. Once a symbol of sight and knowledge, it now becomes a witness frozen between what has ended and what is about to begin.

THE BRANCHES
What Reaches

Bare branches stretch outward like fingers searching through the dark. They represent the roots beneath Winterfell, the ancient network Bran feels shifting something once held back slowly loosening its grip.

Bran finally gathers them all Jon, Sansa, Tyrion, Arya, recalled south for words he refuses to send by raven and tells them everything, his voice steady even as the fire in the hearth gutters low. Silence follows, heavy and disbelieving. But no one at that table has forgotten how easily the war was won, a victory that, in hindsight, felt less like triumph and more like a door swinging quietly open. By the time the candles burn out, the decision is made.Beyond even the Wall′s farthest reach, the land begins to

change in ways none of them have words for a cold that doesn′t simply bite skin but seems to reach for memory itself, dulling thought, blurring the edges of every conversation before it finishes.Frost climbs from the from the horses′ labored breath into strange,

fleeting shapes, curling upward like something trying, and failing, to form words before the wind tears them apart entirely. No one speaks for hours. Even the horses begin to slow, their heads lowered as though listening to something buried beneath the snow.Tracks disappear behind them

almost as soon as they are made, erased by a wind that seems to move with purpose rather than weather. Arya notices that no birds cross the sky. Jon notices that the silence has become heavier. And somewhere beyond the white horizon, something shifts beneath the ice slowly enough that no one can say they saw it move at all.

they find the Ruin

at dusk architecture from no builders any of them can name, runes older than Valyrian, older than the First Men. Tyrion goes pale reading fragments he half-remembers from Sam′s old books. ″What is it?″ Jon asks. Tyrion doesn′t answer. Some silences say enough.

Bran wargs deeper than he′s ever dared past wolves, past the Night King′s borrowed memories, into a breath held for ten thousand years. For one unbearable instant, he sees it. His body goes rigid in the snow. When he returns, gasping, he won′t describe what he saw. He can′t.

By firelight, Tyrion reads burned scrolls naming ″the first fire″ and ″the first frost″ a war older than the Long Night itself. He says nothing for a long while. Nearby, Arya finds animal carcasses arranged in a perfect circle in the snow. ″Something′s testing the edges,″ she says. ″Something out there is curious about us.″

Deep in the ruin′s floor, ancient ice begins to give not melting, but yielding to pressure from below. Where it cracks, no water pools. Only a thin curl of something rises, and impossibly, it smells like smoke over snow. Every torch in camp flickers at once.

Deep beneath the ruin′s floor, ice that has held firm for ten thousand years begins, at last, to give not melting from warmth, but yielding to pressure from below, something vast and patient finally leaning its full weight against the seal. Where the ice cracks, no water pools beneath it. Only a thin curl of something rises through the fracture, and impossibly, unmistakably, it smells like smoke drifting over fresh snow. Every torch in camp flickers at once, as though the air itself has changed.

They stand frozen at the edge of the crack, not from the cold, but from understanding arriving one moment too late to matter. No shape climbs out to meet them

No monster reveals itself to be fought, or bargained with, or feared in any way they know how to name. There is only a sound, felt in the bones more than heard, rolling up from beneath the shattering ice a breath, held for ten thousand years, finally, terribly released.

Bran closes his eyes. He already knows what the others are only just beginning to understand.

It isn′t the end of winter.

It′s the end of the quiet that came before something far, far worse.